Aurora Lake Research Station

Operations Manual, 2026 edition

1. About the Station

The Aurora Lake Research Station is a freshwater research facility on the northern shore of Aurora Lake. It was founded in 2009 and was expanded with a new laboratory wing in 2024. The station is operated by the Northern Lakes Institute. Research at the station focuses on water quality, fish populations and ice cover.

2. Occupancy and Accommodation

The station can accommodate a maximum of 24 residents at any time. Residents stay in the north dormitory, which has 12 twin rooms. Visiting researchers may stay for up to 21 consecutive days per visit. Family accommodation is not covered by this manual; visitors should contact the station office.

3. Requesting a Research Boat

Boat requests must be submitted through the FieldDesk system at least 48 hours before departure. Each request must list the crew, the sampling site and the planned return time. The duty officer reviews and approves every boat request. Approval is not automatic. Trips beyond the outer buoy line require additional written approval from the station director.

4. Safety Rules

Summer safety: life jackets must be worn on all boats from May to September. At least two people must be on every boat. Winter safety: walking on the lake ice is permitted only when the measured ice thickness is at least 15 centimetres. Ice travel is never allowed alone, and every ice team must carry a satellite messenger.

5. Sampling Schedule

Water samples are collected every Monday at six monitoring sites. The samples are sent to the central laboratory every 2 weeks. Fish surveys take place twice a year, in June and in October.

6. Winter Shutdown

The station closes to visiting researchers during the winter shutdown. During the shutdown, two caretakers remain on site to maintain the heating and the monitoring equipment.

7. Equipment Loans

Researchers may borrow sonar units for up to 7 days. Drones may be borrowed for up to 3 days and may only be flown by certified pilots. Lost equipment must be reported to the duty officer within 24 hours.

8. 2026 Update Notice

Following the completion of the laboratory wing, the maximum number of residents at the station is now 30. All other rules in this manual remain unchanged.